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Unity, GNOME Shell and the Notification Area

Do the new desktops succeed in creating intuitive, simple-to-use and distraction-free desktop environments?

It is hard to be passionate about something that everyone does! I was reminded of this by a blog about a survey, which found the WebOS users as the most passionate about their platform. This isn't surprising, because if you are going to buy a product used by a small minority, you are likely to be passionate about it. So, it is nice that Ubuntu is bringing some competition and passion into the desktop world, by differing from the standard GNOME desktop. The difference may be only skin-deep, but it is the skin that users see. There are, however, differences in applets and extensions.

Unity on Ubuntu 11.04

The Unity interface of Ubuntu 11.04 was not a surprise; I have been using it with the Ubuntu 10.10 Netbook Edition. On the desktop, unlike on the netbook, the application did not start with a maximised window. The Unity interface uses the 'global menu'—i.e., the menu bar for the active window is displayed in the top panel. On the netbook, in particular, this is very attractive since it saves vertical space. However, I love the KDE Plasma Netbook interface even more, as it removes the title bar and hides the panel.

There was a slight surprise when I used 11.04 on the netbook (where applications typically start maximised). However, unlike on Ubuntu 10.10, the dock slides out of the window and hides, making more space available for the active window. The window manager decides on the policy by examining the screen resolution, and there is no separate netbook/desktop option in the GDM menu. In case the hardware does not support 3D effects, Unity falls back to the traditional GNOME desktop.

Behind the scenes, though, there is a major change. The earlier version of Unity used Mutter as a compositing window manager; Ubuntu has switched to using Compiz instead. In case the hardware does not support Compiz, the desktop falls back to the GNOME panels.

GNOME Shell on Arch Linux and Fedora 15

Unlike the Ubuntu Unity interface, the first reaction to GNOME Shell was negative. The panel showed, and the rest of the screen was blank. I waited for something more to happen, but that

was it. So, about the only thing that made sense was to click on 'Activities'—and then the few pre-selected favourite applications showed up. You can find some details about the GNOME Shell design at <https://live.gnome.org/GnomeShell/Design>.

The dock for favourites and active applications is not very different from Unity. You can search for an application and add it to Favourites, or start an application and keep it in Favourites. As more applications are added, the size of the icons decreases. It does keep a sanity check on the minimum size, though the small size could get to be too small, especially if you are using a touch-screen. In the case of Unity, the size of the icons remains fixed, but you can scroll and select an icon. In Unity, there is a small arrow on the left to indicate that an application is running. An arrow on the right indicates that it is the active application. Clicking an icon makes the application active—starting it, if necessary.

In GNOME Shell, there is no difference between the icons of running applications and favourite applications. Clicking on *Activities* displays images of the available windows, and you click one to activate it. The differences are cosmetic, and I do not believe anyone would find either one hard to use. However, if you are used to one, you will find the other a little disconcerting, at first.

At present, there aren't any convenient utilities for customising GNOME Shell. The Arch Linux wiki page <https://wiki.archlinux.org/index.php/GNOME> is a very good starting point for what you may wish to do. I found out how to reduce the size of the excessively fat title bars in this wiki. In case the hardware does not support the Mutter window manager, there is a fall-back mode, which is similar to the GNOME 2 panels.

What about all the little System Tray, oops, Notification Area icons?

Frankly, I had never paid much attention to the icons in the GNOME panel's notification area. Of course, they were useful. They provided easy access to connect to a wireless/3G network, made it easy to control the volume, and provided a minimal interface to pause music, replay